

Transforming Digital Romance: How Women Otome Game Players Re-Interpret and Re-Construct Their Gaming Experiences Through Retrospective Imaginative Involvement

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How players develop intimate experiences through gameplay has been extensively studied in HCI and game research. Yet, while existing work largely focuses on intimacy within gameplay, how players may also intentionally extend game-mediated intimacy beyond the game itself is much less understood. Through an interview study (N=25), we aim to advance this research agenda by leveraging the lens of Retrospective Imaginative Involvement (RII), a framework defined as imaginative revisiting and extension of media experiences after exposure, to examine how Asian women players of otome games (single-player digital games that offer fictional romantic relationships with male characters) re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the game, and how these post-game practices reshape their digital romantic experiences. This work provides initial empirical insights for expanding existing understandings of game-mediated intimate experiences by highlighting players' engagement and disengagement spectrum that contributes to nuanced motivations in RIIs as a new form of play, how otome game-mediated intimacy toward virtual characters can also extend offline meanings, and post-game engagement as a unique space for understanding women players' vulnerabilities. We then propose three high-level design principles to inform future game design that sustains immersive, emotionally fulfilling experiences beyond the gameplay, while mitigating risks we identified.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Otome games, game-mediated intimacy, retrospective imaginative involvement, women gamers

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1 Introduction

Compared to other kinds of relationships (e.g., friendships, mundane social ties), intimacy carries particularly important psychological and behavioral meanings of knowing, loving, and caring between individuals [29]. As such, understanding how players develop intimate experiences through gameplay is a long-standing research agenda in HCI and game research, which reframes digital games as socio-technical infrastructures that actively shape some of the deepest and most personal

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human experiences rather than mere entertainment artifacts [16, 17, 19, 27, 32, 46]. Yet, most existing work has predominantly studied game-mediated intimacy as a phenomenon emerging through in-game social interactions between two or more players, such as co-play, chats, co-presence, or shared activities within traditional online multiplayer games [16, 17, 27, 46] and, more recently, social VR spaces [15, 37, 42]. While some works reveal that game-mediated intimate relationships can carry offline meanings and evolve into emotional attachment and social bonds in offline life [16–18, 57], these studies mainly focus on player-player intimacy that emerges within game spaces.

In response, we believe that there is still a research gap about how players may intentionally organize practices outside the game to replicate, extend, and reconfigure these intimate experiences, even after gameplay ends. Unpacking this would be especially valuable for understanding and designing future digital games that support and sustain more immersive and emotionally fulfilling player experiences beyond the game itself. Therefore, in this paper, we leverage the theoretical lens of **Retrospective Imaginative Involvement (RII)** to explore *how women otome players re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the game, as well as how these post-game practices reshape their digital romantic experiences* as a uniquely appropriate case for investigating this understudied space. **Otome games**, also known as Romantic Video Games (RVGs), are story-driven single-player games where players pursue romantic relationships with virtual male characters [3, 36, 72]. These games are designed primarily for women and are especially popular among young women in East Asian countries. Our empirical investigation has two foci:

On the one hand, we chose to leverage the lens of RII because it refers to the imaginative continuation of a media experience after exposure, through which individuals mentally, sometimes even physically, revisit or extend the story, characters, and emotions beyond the original encounter [13, 54]. Although prior work in communication, media studies, and fan studies has examined some fandom-based practices such as fan fiction, fan art, cosplay, and parasocial engagement, it often focuses on those activities themselves and related cultural, social, and identity-related meanings [3, 11, 61, 65]. In contrast, RII offers a complementary perspective on how and why fans initially invest in and sustain their emotional connections over time through post-exposure practices. In this sense, RII is particularly appropriate for our investigation and may provide nuanced insights into how and why some players are motivated to continuously engage with and even re-create game-mediated intimate experiences outside the game.

On the other hand, we focus on otome games as a meaningful context for understanding RII in game-mediated intimate experiences and relationships for two reasons. First, compared to traditional media (e.g., novels, films, and TV) where post-exposure engagement is typically studied, otome game, as a form of video games, features more interactive and immersive controls and can provide players with more personal, immersive romantic experiences and unique motivations for post-exposure engagement. Second, compared to other types of video games where romantic or intimate dynamics are often studied through player-to-player interactions, otome games are typically *single-player* games in which a woman player engages in a scripted romantic storyline with virtual male characters. In this case, the scripted romantic storyline for single players remains more open to personal interpretation and adaptation compared to contingent inter-player relationships. This interpretive freedom thus allows players to comfortably extend the romantic experiences and even materialize their personal expectations into more diverse RII activities.

Specifically, we conducted 25 in-depth semi-structured interviews with experienced women otome players who have also actively participated in various otome game-related practices outside the game to address the following two research questions.

- RQ1: What types of unique RII practices have women otome players engaged in, and how do they leverage these practices to re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the otome game itself?
- RQ2: How do women otome players perceive new tensions emerging in these RII practices to re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the otome game itself?

Our study provides initial empirical insights that contribute to existing HCI and games literature in three ways. **First**, we provide rich empirical evidence of how women otome players in this study actively participate in different forms of RII practices through various, often overlapping roles ranging from paying commissioners to paid roleplayers to fulfill their unmet in-game expectations such as personalized narrative control and realistic, embodied romantic interactions, and what challenges may emerge from different commissioners' or roleplayers' perspectives. As existing HCI and games research on otome games remains relatively limited, this work highlights the potential of otome games as a novel and emerging research context to explore marginalized gamers', especially women gamers', complicated emotional experiences and challenges within and beyond gameplay. **Second**, by leveraging RII as a unique lens, these empirical insights also help broaden existing understandings of game-mediated intimate experiences and relationships by unpacking: (1) how our participants' otome game-mediated intimacy toward virtual characters extends beyond the traditional player-player focus mainly studied in previous literature, offering a complementary lens to understand motivations and mechanics in game-mediated romantic experiences; and (2) how our participants consider RII practices as a new form of extended play, broadening existing understandings of player engagement beyond sustained in-game attention to include the motivational mechanics among otome game players that drive uniquely continued, offline romantic investment. **Third**, building on the tensions and trade-offs involved in women otome players' RII practices in this study, we also propose three preliminary high-level design principles to inform future game design that sustain immersive, emotionally fulfilling experiences beyond the game itself while mitigating the risks we identify.

2 Related Work

2.1 Understanding Retrospective Imaginative Involvement in Non-Gaming and Gaming Contexts

At a high level, Retrospective Imaginative Involvement (RII) is defined as post-exposure imaginative continuation of a media experience beyond the original encounter. This framework is grounded in the Model of Narrative Comprehension and Engagement and the Temporarily Expanding the Boundaries of the Self (TEBOTS) theory [31, 60]. TEBOTS argues that when people experience their everyday self as constrained, they turn to narratives to temporarily augment who they can be, what they can do, and how connected they feel. Building on this understanding, RII specifically aims to capture *how people continue to engage with narratives after exposure, rather than only during reading, watching, or playing* [13, 59], as they may continue to offer similar augmented experiences [25, 52]. These engagements are inherently personalized, shaped by individual experiences, preferences, and prior knowledge of the narrative worlds [50, 55, 74, 77]. They also often manifest as concrete interpretations or materializations of characters, events, and the story world, as seen in fan practices such as fan fiction, fan art, cosplay, and para-social relationship work [4, 13, 56].

As a result, RII has been extensively studied in the context of film and television, especially focusing on how it forms organically and the observed outcomes of RII [45, 58, 67]. For example, Ott and Slater [45] argued that building parasocial relationships and engaging in RII jointly sustain long-term enjoyment and appreciation. Similarly, Sherrick et al. [58] integrated RII with

self-determination theory, demonstrating that narrative media can facilitate the sense of autonomy, competence, and relatedness via post-exposure experiences, especially through retrospective reimagination about how narratives can unfold for individuals rather than according to the original authors or creators.

However, scholars have only recently begun discussing the potential of leveraging RII to expand our existing understandings of how and why players continue to engage with gameplay after the game ends. Like traditional media, digital games have also inspired a similar range of fandom-driven creative activities or consumptions such as fan fictions and fan arts [3, 21]. Game studies has similarly shown that players' affective investments in games often extend beyond discrete gameplay sessions through fandom, such as community practices, identity work, and persistent online and offline forms of play [47, 64]. Furthermore, digital games may enable more distinctive, interactive forms of RII compared to traditional media. For example, Yoshimura and Chauveau's study shows that interactive agency with a game character can facilitate emotional immersion, leading to reality detachment, heightened identification with avatars, and higher levels of post-game RII [73]. Recent HCI studies have also explored how players' memories of player-controllable, interactive journeys with game characters can create lasting emotional engagement and desire to re-experience these personalized narratives [7, 9, 54].

Overall, this small body of HCI and games research tends to focus on relatively generic game-related features (e.g., engaging in interactive agency and narrative [54, 73]), which may not capture the nuances across different game genres, player groups, and cultural contexts. Among the game experiences that can potentially drive RII, romantic experiences represent a particularly understudied yet promising context, given their inherent emphasis on emotional investment and sustained affection and how game-related RII can be motivated by people's emotional engagement with narratives [54, 73]. For example, Chess shows how games and popular media can be an important space for women players to mobilize romance, fandom, and selfhood [10]. Therefore, understanding how and why particular games lead to strong emotional immersion and how RII practices are simultaneously shaped by players' unique emotional needs remains a compelling yet understudied direction. This open space thus motivates us to further unpack the potential role of RII in game-mediated intimate experiences, especially in the context of otome games, which we detail in the next section.

2.2 Game-Mediated Intimate Experiences and Otome Games

Game-Mediated Intimate Experiences and Relationships. Existing HCI and game studies have documented game-mediated intimate experiences and relationships across a range of genres and platforms. Examples include dyadic in-game marriage systems in non-fantasy driven multiplayer online games, where enforced virtual partnerships strengthen emotional bonds and facilitate deep self-disclosure between players [16, 17]; simulated intimate experiences and interactions in immersive virtual environments such as *Second Life* [19, 32] or social Virtual Reality (VR) platforms [15, 37, 42]; and romantic relationships emerging within Multiplayer Online Role-Playing Games such as *World of Warcraft* or even esports, where players foster collaborative intimacy even within competitive environments [18, 27, 46, 76]. Yet, despite the diversity of game spaces that can support online intimacy, the majority of games in this area are not designed to support intimate experiences and relationships *per se*. Instead, digital intimacy largely emerges as an unplanned social phenomenon with other human players within the virtual game world and as a byproduct of the actual gameplay (e.g., teaming up to compete against another team). Therefore, digital games specifically designed to foreground players' romantic engagement are particularly valuable but relatively underexplored in understanding how they may shape unique player engagement and strong motivations for post-game imaginative involvement beyond the game itself. One such understudied example is otome games.

An Overview of Otome Games. Otome games are typically defined as story-driven, single-player video games primarily designed for young women, where a player pursues romantic relationships with virtual male characters [36, 66]. The term *otome* comes from an older Japanese word meaning “young unmarried women” [33], reflecting the genre’s original marketing position. These games often do not emphasize multiplayer experiences to ensure an immersive, undisturbed romantic experience with the scripted narratives. Scholars have also situated otome games within broader genres such as Romantic Video Games (RVGs) [61] or Dating Simulation Games (DSGs) [63]. Historically, RVGs and DSGs refer to a broader lineage of romance-oriented games and were not originally synonymous with women-oriented play. A prominent early branch of Japanese dating-sim culture was male-targeted *bishōjo/galge* games, in which players typically interacted with female characters [20, 48, 63]. Otome games later emerged as a women-targeted branch of this wider romance-game lineage, reworking dating-simulation conventions through female protagonists, male love interests, and romance scenarios designed around women players’ desires [21, 33]. In otome gameplay, women players are usually in control of a female avatar, and the narrative unfolds through romance-oriented plotlines that branch according to player choices [3, 33, 61, 63]. Although otome games were once seen as a niche product within Japanese media culture [22], otome games have become increasingly common among young women across Asia in recent years [36, 39].

Yet, research on otome games remains relatively limited [3, 22, 23, 75]. Much of the existing research approaches the genre through gender and feminist perspectives: studies examine how otome games commodify women’s emotional labor and leisure time [21], while others argue that they offer spaces for questioning normative gender expectations and experimenting with alternative femininities and desires [3, 41]. Scholars have also linked the rise of otome games to broader feminist discourses in East Asia [40, 70, 75]. More recently, researchers have begun to attend to otome games as sites of parasocial romance and social support [23, 36]. In particular, research has begun to highlight how interactions with virtual characters throughout gameplay can foster parasocial bonds that persist beyond play sessions [23, 26, 61].

In this sense, otome games inherit key features of romance novels and television dramas by elaborating on emotionally intense love stories that unfold over time and feature a small cast of recurring love interests [3, 22, 33]. As prior RII research has shown that such long-form romantic narratives are especially likely to linger in memory and invite ongoing imaginative elaboration after exposure [4, 45], in this work, we believe that otome games offer a particularly valuable research context for understanding RII in game-mediated intimate experiences and relationships. In particular, this study focuses on live-service otome games (mobile otome games): mobile-first titles that operate as live services and are continually updated with new content (e.g., episodic story chapters, limited-time events). We focus on this live-service form because its large-scale, continuously evolving development model can support richer, more vivid audiovisual interactions, which in turn could deepen players’ sense of immersion. For example, *Love and Deepspace* foregrounds 3D character presentation and cinematic, close-up “face-to-face” encounters, making romantic involvement feel more immediate and embodied [30]. At the same time, live-service otome games cultivate an always-on community culture that persists between updates through social sharing, discussion, and creative activities around characters, events, and story developments, as well as the exchange of information and strategies for better gameplay [22, 36]. Together, these dynamics may sustain long-term post-game engagement and repeatedly reactivate players’ imaginative involvement between game updates, making live-service otome games an ideal case for exploring our research questions.

3 Methodology

3.1 Recruitment and Participants

The university's Institutional Review Board (IRB) approved this study for research ethics. To address the research questions, we conducted semi-structured in-depth interviews with women otome game players to investigate both their gaming experiences within the otome game and how they reinterpret and reconstruct those experiences outside the game itself. Because otome games are most popular in Asian markets, especially China, we focused on recruiting Chinese women players as their active engagement and rich experience with these games would provide profound insights into our research questions, resulting in an all-Chinese women sample. To recruit participants, the first author first attended popular offline otome game conventions for women players in China in May 2025. This helped us better understand the context of RII-related practices in the community and allowed the first author to directly recruit participants. Then, we posted open calls for participation on RedNote, one of the largest social media platforms in China and the main platform used by women otome players in China to share their experiences and communicate with one another. We especially posted such calls under multiple hashtags. These hashtags were chosen because they captured visible and recurring forms of RII-related discussions in the community, such as: "#otomgame (#乙游) OR #coscommission (#cos委托) OR #text-roleplaycommission (#语C委托)." Because each RedNote post can include multiple hashtags and circulate across overlapping topic feeds, we used these hashtags in combination to broaden the visibility of our recruitment posts across both general otome communities and more specific player spaces to reach a wider scope of potential participants. Lastly, a snowball sampling was also used.

We then contacted every participant who expressed interest in participating via their preferred communication method (e.g., email) and provided them with informed consent documents. In total, we conducted 25 semi-structured interviews between June and November 2025. All interviewees were women who identified as participants of otome game-related practices and players of otome games. Their ages ranged from 19 to 36, and their otome gameplay experiences varied from 3 months to 12 years. Table 1 summarizes participants' demographic information and experiences with otome games and related practices. It is important to note that this study focuses on RII practices that extend beyond gameplay itself. Therefore, the length of otome gameplay experience alone does not indicate whether a participant was sufficiently experienced. Rather, we also considered participants' engagement with otome game-related practices outside the game as a crucial indicator of their rich experience. For example, although P21 had only played otome games for 3 months as an actual player, she had been a text roleplayer for other otome players for 3 years 6 months and had been a cosplayer at offline otome game conventions for 3 years (more than 100 times). Table 3 in Appendix provides a supplementary breakdown of participants' RII-related participation histories.

3.2 Interviews

We did not collect names or identifiable information to protect the participants' privacy. Upon receiving consent, we scheduled the interviews and conducted them via video calls, audio calls, or text chat according to participants' preferences. As shown in Table 3 in Appendix, among the 25 interviews, 15 were conducted through video calls, 9 through audio calls, and 1 through text chat. We used the same semi-structured interview guide across all modalities and did not observe systematic differences in the relevance or richness of participants' accounts. Each interview lasted approximately 1.5 hours and focused on participants' personal experiences with otome games and otome game-related practices. All interviews were conducted in Chinese by the first author, a native Chinese speaker.

ID	Age	Offline Relationship Status	Sexual-Relationship	Otome Game Experience	Otome Games Played	Role(s) in Otome Game Communities	Recruitment Method
1	29	Single	Straight	7 months	<i>LDS</i>	CC, TRC	Directly contact
2	25	Single	Straight	1 year 6 months	<i>LDS</i>	CC	Directly contact
3	27	Single	Straight	1 year 6 months	<i>LDS</i>	CC, TRC	Snowball sampling
4	26	Single	Bisexual	1 year 2 months	<i>LDS, LND</i>	CC, CP	Snowball sampling
5	36	Divorced	Straight	8 months	<i>LDS</i>	CC, CP, TR	Snowball sampling
6	28	Engaged	Straight	6 years 6 months	<i>LDS, MLQC</i>	CC, TRC, TR, FAC	Snowball sampling
7	19	Single	Straight	1 year 6 months	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC, BTW</i>	CC, CP, TR	Snowball sampling
8	25	Single	Bisexual	2 years	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC</i>	CC	Open call from RedNote
9	24	Single	Bisexual	1 year 8 months	<i>AOK</i>	CC, CP, TRC, TR, FAC	Open call from RedNote
10	25	Single	Straight	1 year 6 months	<i>LDS, LND</i>	CC, CP, TRC	Open call from RedNote
11	23	Single	Bisexual	5 years	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC, BTW, LBC</i>	CC	Open call from RedNote
12	21	Single	Exploring	3 years	<i>LDS, MLQC, AOK, TOT</i>	CC, TRC	Open call from RedNote
13	22	Single	Straight	3 years 2 months	<i>LDS, LND, BTW</i>	CC, CP	Open call from RedNote
14	25	Single	Bisexual	6 years	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC, BTW, LBC</i>	CC	Open call from RedNote
15	30	Divorced	Bisexual	9 years	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC, BTW, LBC, OTH</i>	CC, CP, FAC	Open call from RedNote
16	25	In a relationship	Straight	2 years	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC, BTW</i>	CC, TRC	Open call from RedNote
17	32	Married	Straight	9 months	<i>LDS</i>	CC	Snowball sampling
18	24	Single	Pansexual	1 year 10 months	<i>LDS, BTW, AOK</i>	CC, CP, TRC, TR, FAC	Open call from RedNote
19	27	Married	Pansexual	1 year 2 months	<i>LDS, LND, OTH</i>	CC, TRC, TR	Open call from RedNote
20	27	Single	Pansexual	8 years	<i>MLQC, LDS, LND, OTH</i>	CC, CP, TRC, FAC	Open call from RedNote
21	27	Single	Asexual	3 months	<i>LDS, LND, MLQC, BTW, LBC, TOT</i>	CP, TR	Open call from RedNote
22	23	Single	Exploring	10 years	<i>LDS, LND, TOT, MLQC, OTH</i>	CC, CP, TR, FAC	Open call from RedNote
23	22	Single	Bisexual	12 years	<i>LDS, LND, TOT, MLQC, OTH</i>	CC, CP, TR, FAC	Open call from RedNote
24	25	Single	Exploring	2 years	<i>MLQC, TOT, LDS</i>	CC, TRC, FAC	Open call from RedNote
25	23	Single	Straight	1 year	<i>LDS</i>	CC, CP	Snowball sampling

Table 1. Interviewees' demographics and experiences of otome games and otome game communities. Game abbreviations: *LDS* = *Love and Deepspace*; *LND* = *Light and Night*; *MLQC* = *Mr. Love*; *BTW* = *Beyond The World*; *LBC* = *Lovebrush Chronicles*; *TOT* = *Tears of Themis*; *AOK* = *Ashes of the Kingdom*; *OTH* = other otome games not listed. Role abbreviations: CC = cosplay commissioner (see details in section 4.3); CP = cosplayer (see details in section 4.3); TRC = text-roleplay commissioner (see details in section 4.2); TR = text roleplayer (see details in section 4.2); FAC = fandom art creator (see details in section 4.1).

The semi-structured interviews began with an introduction to the research project and then asked some basic demographic questions. Next, participants were asked about their otome gameplay experiences, including which otome games they had played, how long they had been playing them, and why they started to play these games (e.g., “How long have you been playing otome games?” and “Which otome games have you played? What first drew you to otome games?”). Next, we asked about how, if at all, they have engaged in otome game communities outside the games themselves (e.g., “How long have you been involved in these communities both online and offline? Have you met any new friends or acquaintances there?”). We specifically asked them to reflect upon *any online and offline practices in which they continued to engage with the game narratives, characters, and emotional resonance in an imaginative and performative way outside the actual otome game*. This information helped us orient the conversation toward their engagement with and perceptions of RII practices

beyond the otome game itself. For example, we asked, *"What do these extended practices outside the game itself mean to you? Do you feel they bring joy or fulfill your needs? Why or why not?"* and *"Do you see these practices as 'reproducing the game experience' or 'creating new experiences'? Why or why not?"* We also asked if they had encountered any tensions, frustrations, and risks when engaging in these practices outside the game (e.g., *"Have you had unpleasant experiences in otome game communities, both online and offline? If yes, could you share an example?"*). Lastly, participants were encouraged to reflect on and envision future digital game design aimed at supporting and sustaining more immersive and emotionally fulfilling player experiences beyond the game itself, while also mitigating potential risks.

3.3 Data Analysis

After completing the interviews, the first author, a native Chinese speaker and fluent English speaker, translated and transcribed the Chinese-based interviews into English transcriptions. We then conducted an in-depth qualitative analysis of the interview data. In line with Braun and Clarke's guidelines for reflexive thematic analysis [8], the first author first familiarized herself with the data by reading the transcripts line by line, taking analytic notes, and marking excerpts relevant to the research questions, particularly around how women otome players engage in RII practices. She then carried out an iterative coding process, assigning and refining preliminary codes across multiple passes. Next, the first author grouped related codes into preliminary themes and subthemes grounded in participants' own accounts, such as themes capturing how players used different RII practices to augment characters and inscribe their own interpretations onto virtual characters and offline events.

All authors then collaboratively reviewed and discussed the preliminary themes and subthemes, provided feedback on how well they captured the nuances of the data and aligned with the research questions, and worked together to refine the themes and subthemes. The Retrospective Imaginative Involvement theory [13, 59] described in section 2 informed this collaborative coding process because it provides insights into the mechanisms of post-experience imaginative engagement. Therefore, it served as a guiding interpretive lens to help us make sense of participants' post-game practices and better situate our findings in prior research. However, we did not use RII theory to map our data. Instead, themes were not "discovered" in the data but were constructed through conversations and mutual agreements among the authors. For instance, we argued that in the otome game context, fandom art creators often adopt a first-person, self-insert perspective to intensify immersion. In contrast, offline dating simulations through cosplay commissions extend romantic imaginative practices from online to offline settings in more emotionally intense and embodied ways.

Based on these discussions, the first author further integrated and clarified the thematic structure, defined and named the final themes, and drafted the findings section with the most compelling and representative quotes as appropriate examples to demonstrate the breadth and nuance of each theme. The co-authors then reviewed and collaboratively refined the final themes and interpretations to produce a clear narrative structure to address our research questions [8].

Positionality Statement. When conducting reflexive TA, it is crucial to acknowledge how researchers' identities and cultural backgrounds may shape the research process and the analysis and interpretation of data [8, 38, 53]. Such disclosure also helps clarify the researchers' position in the world, their goals, and, to an appropriate extent, their intellectual and political commitments related to the research focus [6]. We acknowledge that our interpretations are shaped by our prior experience with the otome games community and by our own identity as women gamers/games researchers. In particular, the first author, who conducted all interviews and the initial data analysis, is an Asian woman and an experienced otome game player, with prior experience of participating

in both online and offline otome game-related activities. The first author's familiarity with otome games, characters, storylines, and popular RII practices in the community thus helped her build rapport with participants, understand community-specific references, and ask more grounded follow-up questions during interviews. At the same time, the first author's insider familiarity may have shaped who felt comfortable participating in the study and how participants presented their experiences during interviews. It may also have shaped the selection of quotes and the construction of themes in the initial data analysis. However, the other three authors were familiar with qualitative methods but they did not share the same level of insider familiarity with otome-specific RII communities as the first author. Therefore, they were able to provide different perspectives during the reflexive analytic process, which significantly complemented the first author's insider familiarity. Additionally, three out of four authors are Asian women and all authors are experienced games and HCI researchers. Our various identities and experiences with otome game communities thus helped us better design the interview structure and collaboratively interpret the nuances in participants' accounts regarding their engagement with and perceptions of RII practices outside otome games themselves.

4 RQ1 Findings: How Women Otome Players Leverage Unique Types of RII Practices to re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the game

In this section, we address RQ1 by identifying three distinct types of RII practices women otome players often engage in and explaining how they leverage these activities to re-imagine, perform, and re-construct their gameplay experiences across online and offline spaces.

However, it is important to acknowledge that most of these RII practices in our study were commission-based and involved certain financial dynamics, rather than entirely volunteer-based. As shown in Table 1 and Table 3, among the 25 women otome players in this study, 24 had experiences as a commissioner who paid text-roleplay cosplayers or offline cosplayers in dating simulations; 13 had experiences as cosplayers, and 10 of whom had been paid at least once; and 9 had experiences as text roleplayers who got paid. Additionally, 13 participants had experience on both sides (i.e., as both paying commissioners and paid cosplayers). Despite this financial component in these commission-based RII practices, almost all participants, even those who had only served as paid cosplayers or text roleplayers, did not necessarily frame their participation as solely financially driven or merely a way to make income. Rather, they highlighted that payment was partly necessary to cover the essential cost to prepare cosplay (e.g., outfit and makeup) and their time investment, while their main motivations also included fandom participation, emotional engagement with the characters, and helping commissioners sustain romantic imagination beyond the game. Given that participants engaged in different forms of RII practices from different roles, and that some occupied overlapping positions as both paying commissioners and paid cosplayers or text roleplayers, how they understood and approached these practices was often complex. In our analysis, we therefore also attended to these different roles and perspectives when examining how participants re-interpreted and re-constructed their gaming experiences through RII, as well as what challenges emerged from different commissioners' and performers' perspectives. To provide additional context when participants' accounts involve multiple possible perspectives, we add information where necessary to clarify the participant's relevant role in that account (e.g., P5: cosplay commissioner and cosplayer).

4.1 Leveraging Creative Online Fandom Art Creation as a RII to Re-create First-Person Romantic Storytelling Beyond the Original Script Through Personalized Narrative Control

In our study, many participants (N=8), regardless of whether they had experiences as commissioners, cosplayers, or both, actively engaged in a wide range of *creative online fandom art creation as creators*, typically including fan fictions, illustrations, and video edits (e.g., remixing in-game assets or creating 2D/3D animations), to reimagine gameplay and emotional experiences in otome games. While fandom art creation is a long-standing tradition across various media forms, such as literature and films [13, 65], otome game fandom art creation especially focuses on a first-person romantic narrative through highly personalized writing styles. To otome game players, this fan-art creation is an important way for them to subjectively reimagine and recreate their own romantic experiences beyond the original gameplay.

Indeed, from *creators'* perspective, many participants described such fandom art creation as a meaningful way for them to repeatedly “*chew over*” (i.e., savor key story moments; P6, P19) or “*continue the relationship*” after the game ends (P18, P22). More importantly, these fandom creations usually go beyond simply reflecting on and revisiting the gameplay to customize romantic narratives for themselves. For example, participants unanimously emphasized their focus on “*creat[ing] new plotlines*” (P9, P23) or “*add[ing] own interpretations to the character*” (P6, P19, P22) based on their real-life moods and personal experiences. Several especially highlighted the importance of changing the original story settings to meet their own personal needs, such as in their everyday environments, recent timelines, or a completely different relationship, such as:

“I use fan art to record all the things I imagine with them (game characters) in my head.”
(P6)

“When I write a novel with myself as the protagonist, the writing process itself satisfies my imagination. Once I finish the story, I feel that in my imagination we have already entered another timeline or multiverse and actually done these things.” (P24)

Otome game designs often carefully maintain a first-person gameplay (e.g., face-to-face conversations with virtual characters) to provide immersive and emotionally intense romantic experiences. However, for creators like P6 and P24, merely visual immersion can be insufficient, which may explain their uniquely high demand for more individualized story and their strong motivation to seek “*emotional value that the official storyline simply can’t give*” (P6). As such, their fandom creation serves as an important space for them to transform passive romantic consumption into an active act of self-expression and emotional authorship.

Creators’ strong emphasis on perspective choice in fan art creation further reveals this demand for a deeply personalized experience. P24 noted,

“At first, I wrote some self-insert (describing the protagonist according to myself), first-person perspective fictions just for myself, and later I also started writing in the second-person perspective. I want to create story worlds that allow everyone to project themselves into them.” (P24)

On the one hand, the self-insert, first-person fiction shows how individual creators try to anchor the narrative to their own desires, body, and lived experience in details the original game could not cover, echoing autofictional and confessional writing practices [12, 44, 51]. On the other hand, the second-person fiction narrative reveals how personal details in such romantic experiences would also carry exclusivity that may prevent anyone else from immersing (e.g., mismatched physical descriptions, idiosyncratic romantic preferences). By creating an “open vessel” that any reader can inhabit, second-person writing thus serves the same immersive goal as first-person writing, only redirected from creators themselves toward a broader audience.

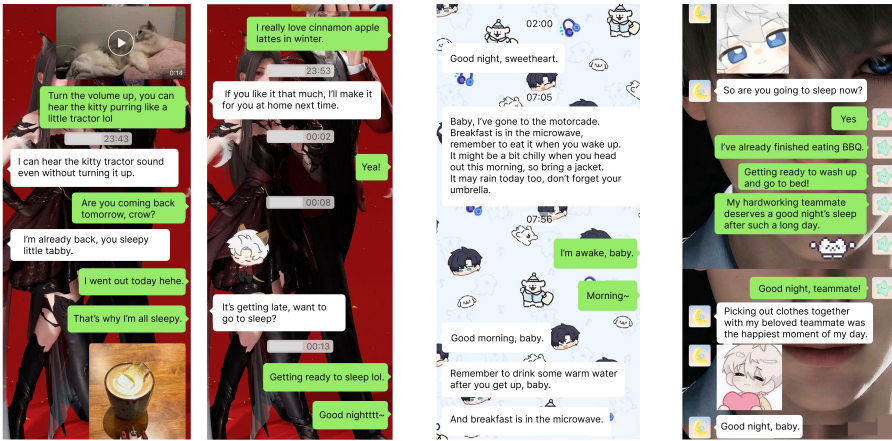


Fig. 1. Examples of text-roleplay chats (screenshots of these chats were posted on RedNote, a public social media platform in China). Messages in white bubbles (left) are from text roleplayers; messages in green bubbles (right) are from commissioners. The exchanges show daily conversations, including greetings, everyday updates, photo/video sharing, and emotional comfort.

4.2 Leveraging Everyday Text-Based Online Roleplay as a RII to Collaboratively Reconstruct Game-Based Romantic Interactions in Mundane Lives Outside the Game

Our participants also highlighted *everyday text-based online roleplay* as a unique RII for collaboratively extending their game-based romantic interactions to everyday lives outside the game (Figure 1). In otome game communities, such text-based roleplay typically occurs through paid commissions, where a paid roleplayer acts as a male character from an otome game, engaging with the commissioner via instant messaging apps “*just like online dating*” (P9; text roleplayer and commissioner). Like fandom art creation, many commissioners who paid for text roleplay similarly described text roleplay as a way to “*write my own story*” or “*complete the experiences absent in the game*” (P9, P6, P24). However, it represents a much more customizable and collaborative everyday experience where women otome players could fine-tune interactive details based on their emotional needs in-the-moment, such as based on the woman player’s own personalities, life experiences, moods, and desired forms of intimacy during a specific moment. Through this form of RII, participants re-interpreted and extended gameplay experiences from both *text-roleplay commissioners’* and *performers’* perspectives. This level of spontaneity allows them to “*create my own little utopia*” (P24; text-roleplayer commissioner) within their everyday mundane lives in the following three ways, which go beyond what traditional RII practices, such as asynchronous online fandom art creation, can achieve.

First, text-based roleplay requires roleplayers to closely align with the original otome game characters’ conversational styles rather than merely imitating game narratives. This offers a sense of genuine human connection that games alone cannot provide. For example, participants unanimously emphasized their high standards for being convincingly “*in character*” when engaging in text roleplay, regardless of whether they would serve as a commissioner or a text roleplayer:

“I [as a text roleplayer] need to repeatedly familiarize myself with the game’s storyline and carefully think through and imitate the character’s temperament. I also write a ‘character profile’ to explain my understanding of the character, how I plan to perform them, and

what my interpretation is. Only when the commissioner is completely satisfied do we start the actual roleplay commission.” (P21; text roleplayer)

“I [as a commissioner who hired the roleplayer] have very high requirements for being ‘in character’. In my view, many text-roleplayers don’t meet that standard at all. Simply imitating the tone and speech habit is not enough—you have to truly be that character.” (P19; text roleplayer and commissioner)

As P19 and P21 revealed, being “in character” requires not only repeating the in-game conversation style but also skillfully improvising responses to various non-game-related daily topics while maintaining character authenticity. These equally stringent requirements for both the commissioner and the roleplayer highlight how text roleplay serves as an important space to support both imaginative romance from fictional characters and the genuine warmth of human connection that games cannot provide. Indeed, when comparing text roleplay with advanced AI chatbots (e.g., ChatGPT), our participants, regardless of whether they had experience as a commissioner or a text roleplayer, particularly highlighted the irreplaceable emotional labor and realistic activities that only human roleplayers can provide. For example, P1 (commissioner) and P22 (text roleplayer and commissioner) shared similar views,

“I still prefer [interacting with] a real person. [...] When I see an AI interface, I always feel it’s cold and distant.” (P1)

“Even if you have a well-tuned AI, it still can’t completely replace text roleplay. It can’t do things with you like listening to music together, watching videos together, or ordering food delivery for you.” (P22)

For both commissioner and text roleplayer, beyond generating genuinely and emotionally satisfying dialogues, human participants can engage in shared activities (e.g., watching videos), perform tangible care (e.g., ordering food), and offer the warmth of knowing another person is present and invested in the interaction. This human presence and connection were key to expanding game-based romantic interactions into everyday life. Whether as commissioners or text roleplayers, participants felt that care and affection became more reciprocal and realistic when sustained by another person.

Second, text roleplay especially emphasizes highly personalized and spontaneous conversations around commissioners’ immediate feelings and life situations in-the-moment. To commissioners, text roleplay became a particularly natural and immersive RII practice because they can “act freely as themselves” (P1, P9, P12, P18) as in their regular everyday lives. For example, P12 and P9 explained,

“Because everything in the game is set by the program, everyone’s experience is basically the same. But in text roleplay, I [as a commissioner] play the role of a girlfriend, and it’s still mostly my own personality. My appearance and personality settings are basically who I am. So it’s like my own game, my own story.” (P12)

“I wanted to share my daily life with my favorite character—to talk about my own life rather than the ‘female avatar’s’ life, and to say more about myself.” (P9)

By integrating imaginative characteristics into spontaneous, situational conversations, commissioners can guide the emotional tone and narrative direction of the interaction and receive immediate responses that mirror the attentiveness expected in genuine romantic interactions. In this way, text roleplay can turn fantasy-based imagination into more personalized and realistic immersion outside the game itself by grounding it in the women players’ everyday lived experiences.

Third, text roleplay creates sustained, relational engagement to extend game-based romantic interactions over time. Several commissioners described text roleplay lasting for months, during which such roleplay has been woven into their everyday routines and formed a relational dynamic between them and the roleplayers (P3, P6, P9, P12, P16, P18, P20). P16 (commissioner) summarized, “My roleplay partner became involved in my daily life. I could talk to them whenever I wanted; sometimes

I even treated them as a place to write diaries and record my day-to-day activities." Participants also highlighted that this constant engagement in text roleplay is especially valuable for individuals navigating difficult periods in their real lives. For example,

"Sometimes the pressure of real life needs to be relieved in ways that are more hormonal, more romantic, and happier. [...] These [text roleplay] bring me joy in a way I expected, in doing so, some of the gloom from my real life was diluted and prevented my negative emotions from piling up." (P18; text roleplayer and commissioner)

"Last semester felt constantly down. But I didn't have friends I could talk to all the time. [...] So I started text-roleplay, and it lasted three or four months. That period really 'nourished' me—there was constant expression, reception, back-and-forth, and encouragement." (P20; commissioner)

Here, from commissioners' perspectives, they described how text roleplay functions as emotional support to their respective personal lives: while P18 described text roleplay as a positive counterbalance for them to feel "joy", P20 especially highlighted the substitutive value when she *"felt constantly down"* but did not have instant access to other supportive mechanisms (e.g., friendships). For these players, text roleplay thus evolves into a sustained, adaptive relational presence: one that can absorb sudden emotional shifts, offer comfort during acute distress, and provide ongoing encouragement across extended, difficult periods in ways that neither the game itself nor asynchronous fan creation can.

4.3 Offline Dating Simulation as a RII to Transform Digital Romance into Embodied Offline One-Day Fantasy

Lastly, our participants highlighted offline dating simulation as a crucial RII practice for a more immersive, embodied offline fantasy (Figure 2). This practice usually involves a "one-day dating" (6–8 hours) through cosplay commission, where a commissioner pays for a cosplayer to dress and act as an otome game male character. To many participants, regardless of whether they would serve as a commissioner or a cosplayer, offline dating simulations went beyond merely an offline version of text roleplay but significantly transformed their online only, game-based romantic experiences through two unique features to *"make a dream come true"* (P5; commissioner and cosplayer).

First, both commissioners and cosplayers in this study described cosplay commission as an essential, sometimes the only, way for them to experience embodied romantic interactions, because it could offer *"a physical space to express real affection"* (P2, P3, P11, P13, P16, P25). From the commissioner's perspective, they emphasized the importance of physical interactions in fostering genuine feelings of care and emotional reliability beyond mere digital romance:

"It's (cosplay commission) kind of like bringing my favorite character from the two-dimensional world into the three-dimensional one. In real life, I really like physical closeness and touch, like cuddling and having contact. But there's no way a real Rafayel (an otome game character) could exist in everyday life, so I can only do it through cosplay commissions, holding hands with the performer, hugging, things like that." (P3; commissioner)

"a key part of cosplay commissions is that the cosplayer—embodying the character's 'perfect face'—spends the entire day focused on me. It also lets me do 'three-dimensional' dating activities with him that I've imagined, such as going to the cinema, having meals together, and taking photos. It feels like my favorite character comes into my real life, which makes me feel genuinely happy." (P22; commissioner and cosplayer)

For cosplay commissioners like P3 and P22, the ability to hold hands, embrace, or receive a gentle kiss on the cheek provides tangible confirmation of affection, deepening the emotional security that participants described as irreplaceable. Furthermore, beyond individual physical intimacy, cosplay

commissions also enable commissioners to engage in “three-dimensional dating activities” to enact these tangible affections across various real-world settings that neither online fandom art creation nor screen-based text roleplay can replicate.

Even for *cosplayers* (i.e., players hired to dress and act as an otome game male character), engaging in this dating simulation can be emotionally meaningful, for instance:

“I really love this character, and participating in cosplay commission as a cosplayer comes from this urge to bring him into the real world. [...] During the performance, I genuinely feel that this is the day when I am closest to Sylus (the character) himself. Every word I say and every action I take, I think about what he would do if he were here.” (P25; cosplayer and commissioner)

“Through my performance, he (the virtual character) becomes something more like a soul. He goes beyond the digital—beyond data. Yes, he becomes part of my flesh and blood.” (P18; cosplayer and commissioner)

For cosplayers like P18 and P25, participation in cosplay commission also deepened their emotional investment and personal understanding of the character by embodying the character’s storyline, emotions, and personality. In this sense, even as paid cosplayers, “acting out” romantic interactions with commissioners also became a way for them to deepen and reinterpret their emotional resonance with the beloved character beyond their existing game experiences.

Second, while cosplay commission aims to simulate a date with a virtual male persona, our participants who participated as commissioners unanimously highlight the women-only participation rule, and they would feel uncomfortable or unsafe if a male cosplayer was involved, regardless of their performance quality (P1, P3, P5, P7, P9, P11, P12, P14, P15, P16, P25). While “*dating between two straight girls*” (P4, P7, P24) might initially appear paradoxical in the context of otome games’ heterosexual romance, for many, this women-only structure is crucial for both safety and emotional authenticity. For example:

“Personally, I feel that men sometimes don’t really understand what women need. For example, if I happened to be on my period on the day of a date, a woman would probably comfort me right away, maybe go buy me a drink or something. But a man might at most say, ‘Why are you being so dramatic? It’s just your period.’ Or, ‘It’s just menstrual cramps, just drink more hot water.’ That’s usually how it goes.” (P8; commissioner)

“When I told my partner (the cosplayer) that I was struggling because of hormones and low energy at work, she wrote a long comforting message. Even though she used the tone of the virtual male character, I felt a kind of respect and care that only another woman would truly understand.” (P1; commissioner)

For these commissioners, a women-only space not only avoided direct safety risks but also ensured more emotionally sensitive understandings of women’s psychological and bodily experiences by fellow women players (e.g., menstrual pain mentioned by P8 and “*a kind of respect and care that only another woman would truly understand*” highlighted by P1). Some participants even began to reflect upon and revisit their own understanding of sexuality, as P24 (commissioner) revealed:

“I realized that aside from the romantic feeling brought by the male character she played, the cosplayer herself was wonderful. A girl can understand my emotions, how I hope someone responds in romance. [...] I never thought girls could date girls, but now I feel maybe I can.”

These dynamics suggest a more profound RII outcome, which allows participants to reflect on and experiment with what intimacy meant to them. From commissioners’ perspectives in particular, these offline one-day fantasies may go far beyond merely a physical enactment of an imagined



Fig. 2. Examples of offline dating simulations through cosplay commissions: a commissioner and a cosplayer simulate a romantic relationship from the otome game through offline activities such as dining, shopping, and photo-taking (all photos were collected per participants' prior agreement and consent).

relationship but become a safe experimental space for exploring intimacy, relationships and even sexuality.

5 RQ2 Findings: Tensions Emerging in RII Practices

While participants leveraged these three RII practices to reconstruct game-based digital romance beyond the game itself, they also expressed concerns about three emerging tensions that may surface or intensify pre-existing vulnerabilities in their personal lives. These concerns may not fully reflect the experiences of all women otome players or capture a comprehensive picture of the tensions they face. Yet, these findings still reveal the nuanced challenges our participants face in negotiating intimacy, desire, identity, and selfhood through RII practices.

5.1 Over-Idealization Risks May Emerge in Women Otome Players' RII Practices and Spill into Expectations of Their Offline Selves and Relationships

For our participants, their RII practices could offer various emotional experiences beyond the gameplay itself, which sometimes provided unique emotional relief for their real-life challenges. However, some participants also described how these practices could simultaneously reflect and reinforce their desire for "perfect" or even outright "flawless" romantic experiences.

For example, as participants engage in idealized romantic scripts, several who had experiences as *commissioners* described growing anxiety about not being able to live up to the version of themselves they performed during RIIs. P18 recalled that she *"never felt good enough."* For her, maintaining an idealized self is equally important as requiring an "in-character" roleplayer. Therefore, her everyday life experiences after the roleplay may gradually create a contrast that she personally associated with feelings of anxiety. P11 even highlighted how she seemed to develop a sense of *"low self-worth"* after engaging in cosplay commissions, feeling exhausted to continuously present a *"more perfect"* version of herself to prove that she deserved the "imagined romance."

Additionally, many *commissioners* in this study reported that, after engaging in highly satisfying RIIs, they increasingly felt they *"can't put up with men in everyday life"* (P1, P3, P7, P10, P15, P24, P25). P10 shared an extreme case,

"After I've done so many [RII things], you realize that men in real life just aren't that handsome. In the three-dimensional world, men don't have good appearances, nice characteristics, or thoughtful care —so why should I choose you? [...] I don't think it's possible to find someone in real life whom I would feel is worthy of the same level of love in return."

By comparing the "idealized men" from commissions with men in everyday life, these commissioners found it more difficult to engage in more realistic but less ideal offline romantic relationships.

However, why such over-idealization may emerge in their RII practices is complicated. For some commissioners, this tendency of over-idealization was not directly related to the specific context of otome games but prior personal emotional vulnerabilities. P5 (cosplay commissioner and cosplayer/text roleplayer), who had experienced divorce and relational trauma in her personal life, described herself as “*seriously anti-male*”:

“These characters are designed to be flawless as ideal lovers, except they don’t exist in real life. If I want a relationship that is purely perfect, I can only get it through commissions.”

Here, P5’s prior emotional vulnerability could potentially further shape why she built emotional attachment to idealized lovers. In this case, the temporary relief may create additional barriers for these commissioners to effectively manage and recover from their traumatizing and emotionally vulnerable experiences in the long run.

5.2 Unhealthy Re-Engagement Cycles May Emerge in Women Otome Players’ RII Practices

Some participants were also worried that, as the imaginative RII activities only provided emotional relief rather than addressing underlying stressors or building resilience and problem-solving capacities, the temporary escape might reveal and reinforce pre-existing emotional dependency and escapism, instead of helping them engage actively with real-world challenges.

Indeed, some participants already highlighted **the difficulty for them to transition back to everyday life**, which often happened when an imagined romantic experience ended and they had to return to everyday life. For instance, P13 and P8 admitted that they, as commissioners, cried at the end of the offline dating simulation experience:

“I cried so hard in front of the cosplayer, I just did not want to go back to the reality. [...] Time passed so quickly, and then it was over again. The dream I created for myself had ended.” (P13)

“During the one-day cosplay commission date, the performer gave me so much emotional value. That day I could completely relax, so I didn’t have to be an adult. I could be a little mischievous and be like a kid. [...] Even now, after so many dates, I still get withdrawal. When we part, I still cry. The next day and the day after, I still feel a bit sad and empty, and I just want the next date to come as soon as possible.” (P8)

Here, ending commissioners’ immersion in the offline dating simulations not only caused immediate emotional resistance (i.e., crying), but also created a continuous emptiness that lasted long after the commission ended (i.e., for days). As a result, some commissioners chose to immediately engage in new RII practices again to mitigate this sense of emptiness and discomfort. P1, for instance, described that she could only “*recover quickly*” by finding a new text roleplay partner soon afterward.

Therefore, some participants called this behavior **repetitive re-engagement cycles**. Some even used terms that were typically used to describe addiction to warn of the potential risk of these unhealthy re-engagement cycles, for example: using the phrase “*actively overdose*” (P8, P9, P14) to describe RII practices as a primary way to sustain their emotional stability, considering RII practices as their only “*antidepressant*” for getting through challenging times in real life (P9; cosplay/text-roleplay commissioner, cosplayer and text roleplayer), and even claiming to place RII-related spending above basic living needs (“*I can choose not to eat, but I would still want to spend money on these roleplays*” - P9).

5.3 Confusion Between Performance and Genuine Human Connections May Emerge in Women Otome Players' RII Practices

Furthermore, participants often faced confusions and struggles between their expectations for genuine human connections and the performance nature of their RII practices, regardless of whether they engaged as *commissioners* or *performers*. These struggles are particularly evident given the fact that almost all text-based and offline cosplay commissions are paid. While monetization does not negate the genuine emotional investment that both commissioners and cosplayers bring to these practices (e.g., both parties often express authentic care and deep connection to the characters they love), it may introduce a paradoxical emotional struggle. For example, P12 shared her story as a cosplay/text-roleplay commissioner,

"I think it's my possessiveness toward the character being projected onto the cosplayer or text-roleplay performers. Most of the time, I understand she's a commissioned performer, not the character [. . .] but I still imagine all these commissioners as different 'owners.' I want her to be like the character—only good to me, and belong to me. This mix of roles is really complicated and makes me struggle all the time."

For P12, even though she was fully aware that the cosplayer is not the character, engaging in RII practices with the cosplayer still made it difficult for her to distinguish between simulations and genuine human feelings. As a result, she projected her expectations for a long-lasting romantic relationship onto the cosplayer. Such a deep engagement, while valuable for temporary emotional relief, could potentially foster an unhealthy, possessive attachment to the performer (e.g., making the cosplayer "belong to" her).

Such boundary confusion also happened to paid cosplayers. P15 added,

"Looking back, we realized that we were both too deeply immersed in character. She [commissioner] loved me as if she were the character, and I, in turn, was loving the 'shadow' of that character in her. In the end, this excessive immersion caused everything to blend together, leaving us both emotionally overwhelmed."

Here, as a paid performer, P15 was overly immersed in RII practices and even entered a real-life romantic relationship with her commissioner. However, both parties eventually realized that their relationship was shaped by being "too deep in character" and thus became brief and emotionally confusing.

In this sense, this confusion did not arise solely from deep emotional immersion but was also reinforced by the **tension between financial exchange and romantic engagement** in commission-based RII practices. From the *commissioners'* perspective, relationships built around payment and paid performance roles could lead them to question whether the care and intimacy they received were genuine or merely performed. Several participants expressed doubts about performers' motivations. As commissioners, they described the care and affection they received as existing "only by money" (P2, P8, P13, P21) or reflecting the idea that "there is no free lunch" (P2; cosplay commissioner). They did not deny the emotional value of the encounter. However, the payment structure made the relationship feel fragile: the possibility of a romantic connection depended on an economic exchange that simultaneously enabled and undermined the fantasy.

From the *performers'* perspective, this ambiguity could become even sharper because "professional performers" do exist within the community. P21 (cosplayer and text roleplayer), who described herself as a full-time professional cosplayer and text-roleplayer, stated, "I have absolutely no feelings for these game characters. I study and learn about them seriously only for the money." This shows that commissioners and performers could enter the same RII practice with different motivations: while one might seek romantic intimacy and emotional repair, the other might treat the interaction as skilled paid labor. This role-based difference again explains why paid RII practices could both

RQ1: What types of unique RII practices have women otome players engaged in, and how do they leverage these practices to re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the otome game itself?	
1. Creative Online Fandom Art Creation	- Otome fandom creators create first-person romantic storytelling through personalized narrative control (e.g., self-insert fan fiction, illustrations, video edits) - Otome fandom creators deliberate second-person perspective that minimizes author-specific details, enabling broader players to immerse themselves from their own perspectives
2. Text-Based Online Roleplay	- Commissioners valued genuine "in-character" interactions beyond the game, enabled by roleplayers' close replication of character styles and improvisation. - Commissioners experienced highly personalized and spontaneous conversations centered on their real-time feelings and life situations. - Both commissioners and text roleplayers sustain daily engagement that extends game-based romantic interactions over time.
3. Offline Dating Simulation through Cosplay Commission	- One-day dating experience offering both commissioners and cosplayers embodied romantic interactions (e.g., touch, shared activities) unavailable in digital play. - Women-only spaces ensure both physical safety and emotional authenticity for commissioners through shared romantic understandings.
RQ2: How do women otome players perceive new tensions emerging in these RII practices to re-interpret and re-construct their gaming experiences outside the otome game itself?	
Risk 1: Over-Idealization Spilling into Offline Life	- Maintaining an idealized self in RII practices is associated with commissioners' emotional pressure and dissatisfaction with one's offline self. - Repeated exposure to idealized romance may heighten commissioners' unrealistic expectations for real-world relationships.
Risk 2: Unhealthy Re-Engagement Cycles	- <i>Emotional dependency</i>: RII offers commissioners temporary relief but may not build real-world resilience. - <i>Difficulty transitioning back to everyday life</i>: Commissioners may experience distress and emptiness when RII sessions end, and real life resumes. - <i>Repetitive and unhealthy re-engagement cycles</i>: Commissioners may form repetitive relief-and-re-immersion loops in response to emotional discomfort that arises after a session ends.
Risk 3: Confusion Between Performance and Genuine Human Connections	- Both commissioners and performers may struggle to distinguish performative intimacy in RII from genuine human affection. - Money complicates the boundary between romantic connection and performed service, as commissioners may question whether care is genuine while performers may approach the interaction as skilled paid labor.

Table 2. Summary of key findings

sustain romantic imagination and produce confusion, leaving the boundary between romantic connection and performed service unstable or even harmful.

6 Discussion

As summarized in Table 2, our participants have revealed how they leverage three unique forms of RII practices spanning online and offline spaces to create romantic experiences beyond the original gameplay (**RQ1**). However, they also highlight that the same features that make these RII practices powerful and emotionally fulfilling for them can also create complex and sometimes even vulnerable experiences (**RQ2**). Based on these insights, we first discuss how our findings provide initial empirical insights for contributing to HCI and games literature on game-mediated intimate experiences and relationships across online and offline spaces through the unique lens of RII in otome games (**6.1**). Reflecting upon both the nuances and tensions of leveraging RII practices to augment our participants' gameplay experiences, we then identify potential directions

for designing future digital games to support and sustain more immersive and emotionally fulfilling player experiences beyond the game itself, while also mitigating potential risks associated with such enhanced intimate experiences and relationships (6.2).

6.1 Towards Re-visiting Game-Mediated Intimate Experiences and Relationships Across Online and Offline Spaces Through the Lens of RII in Otome Games

As highlighted at the beginning of this paper, an extensive body of existing HCI and games literature has focused on how people develop intimate experiences through gameplay, ranging from deliberate in-game virtual marriage systems [16, 17], spontaneous online romantic relationships emerging between players (e.g., through collaborative and team-based gameplay [18, 27, 46]), and simulated physicalized interactions in social VR (e.g., falling asleep with a long-distance partner in social VR [15]). Yet, the majority of such interactions are bounded within specific game systems and mechanics [27], leading existing studies to primarily focus on how players approach and engage with potential intimate experiences and relationships within game spaces. Our findings thus extend existing literature on game-mediated intimacy by revealing how women otome players reconstruct romantic experiences beyond the game through RII practices, which we discuss below.

6.1.1 Towards Re-visiting Player Disengagement as a Probe to Understand Nuanced Motivations in Romantic Play. In games research, player engagement is often understood as a state of sustained attention, emotional involvement, and motivation to continue play [1], typically examined within the temporal and spatial boundaries of gameplay [71]. In this framing, players' motivations are commonly attributed to positive experiences such as enjoyment, immersion, and attachment to characters [49, 71]. Meanwhile, recent work has also begun to argue for a more holistic view of player experience that considers both engagement and disengagement as interconnected processes unfolding across entry into, persistence within, and exit from play [2]. Our study thus contributes to expanding the understanding of disengagement in games by exploring how women otome game players' disengagement may unpack nuanced motivations in romantic play.

First, our findings about participants' sensitivity to immersion can add new insights into how we understand nuanced disengagement in play. For example, while previous research highlights avatar identification as a key mechanism for deepening immersion [61], our findings reveal the nuanced difficulty for our participants to fully identify with the protagonist avatar due to discrepancies with their own identity, presentation, mood, and real-life situation in first-person romantic gameplay. This can make their in-game romance to feel like the protagonist's love story rather than their own. Such an experience of being both immersed and held at a distance thus extends the holistic perspective grounded in clear signals (e.g., exit play [2]) by highlighting a spectrum along engagement-disengagement to focus on the nuanced frictions that arise when players are still actively involved in gameplay.

Second, our work also provides initial insights and empirical evidence on how this nuanced disengagement directly motivates women otome players in this study to engage in various post-game RII practices, revealing an additional space for understanding players' unmet romantic and identity expectations. For our participants, their RII practices foreground important limits in games' ability to provide a personalized, realistic romantic experience. For example, many participants complain that otome games fall short narratively. They also feel that otome games cannot afford the forms of physical and emotional intimacy that make them feel genuinely cared for. In this sense, **RII practices are not supplementary fan behavior but a substantive extension that surfaces these core play expectations and emotional desires.** Compared to traditional analytical frameworks that focus primarily on in-game experiences, our study thus highlights

how post-game activities can also, and sometimes even more effectively, reveal authentic player expectations and the kinds of romantic engagement they ultimately seek.

6.1.2 Towards Re-visiting Player-Character Intimate Relationships beyond the Traditional Player-Player Paradigm. Another unique highlight of our findings is that game-based romantic relationships with virtual characters can also extend offline meanings through nuanced RII practices, which potentially creates more personalized, focused experiences. Previous literature on HCI and game studies has already shown that game-mediated intimate relationships can carry offline meanings. For example, research on multiplayer online games demonstrates that relationships formed through in-game collaboration can carry over into offline social ties [57]. Similarly, research on esports communities shows that social support often extends beyond the game, forming long-term, ongoing social bonds in players' offline lives [18]. However, prior work has largely documented this extension in the context of social relationships between two (or more) players, such as friendships and community bonds [18, 57].

In contrast, unlike player-player bonds, the virtual character is narratively fixed yet imaginatively open, giving players full creative control over how the relationship develops outside the game. This openness thus affords participants the opportunity to invest significant effort and resources into guaranteeing the quality of that reconstruction. As our findings show, commissioners held high standards for roleplayers to be convincingly "*in character*," requiring them to study the character's temperament, write detailed character profiles, and satisfy the commissioners before any roleplay began. Similarly, cosplay commissioners carefully selected performers who could authentically embody not just the character's appearance but their emotional presence. By centering player-character dynamics, these RII practices thus become a more structured and controllable relational space, where women players in this study can articulate their personal desires and emotional needs for intimacy in ways that player-player relationships may not directly accommodate.

Therefore, our findings both extend and provide initial insights into existing understandings of game-mediated intimacy by moving beyond the traditional player-player paradigm. Although other players are still involved in women otome players' RII practices, the main goal is to transfer their attachment to virtual characters into their offline lives through collaborative role-playing with other players, rather than building intimate relationships with other players *per se*. Essentially, these players are still seeking to extend player-character romantic experiences in their everyday lives, while player-player interactions serve as their infrastructure rather than the ultimate goal.

6.1.3 Towards Re-visiting Post-Game Engagement as a Unique Space for Understanding Women Players' Inherent Needs and Vulnerabilities. Prior research in HCI and game studies has documented persistent harms and toxicity against marginalized and vulnerable groups, such as LGBTQ players [5], racial minorities [24], emotionally sensitive individuals [35], and women players [14, 34], in digital game environments. These patterns reveal that while game spaces can introduce new harms, these harms could be amplified for player groups with specific social and emotional vulnerabilities, such as women. Our work also extends this understanding by revealing how post-game RII makes such vulnerabilities especially visible in ways that in-game analysis alone may not capture.

As our findings show, participants' motivations to enter and sustain RII practices can sometimes be shaped by pre-existing emotional circumstances, including relationship histories, personal dispositions, and, in some cases, prior trauma. For example, several commissioners described turning to text roleplay during prolonged periods of emotional difficulty. For them, such practices could become a reliable relational presence that offered ongoing encouragement through extended hardships in ways neither the game itself nor their immediate social environments could provide. Some participants' RII practices often take on intensified soothing and escapist functions to provide a structured and controllable setting to counter uncertainty and dissatisfaction. For them, the

structured and controllable intimacy that RII offers (e.g., through a “flawless ideal lover”) felt not merely pleasurable but at times necessary. RII thus offers a unique space for understanding the women players’ inherent needs and vulnerabilities that gameplay itself leaves unaddressed.

Importantly, this new space to understand player vulnerability also provides valuable angles for designing for player well-being. As RII is entirely self-motivated and player-driven, it reveals players’ own unmediated emotional needs as they reach beyond the game to reconstruct and sustain intimate experiences. We thus turn to consider how these insights might inform the design of future games and game ecosystems to support more immersive and emotionally fulfilling player experiences beyond the game itself.

6.2 Design Future Digital Games for Supporting and Sustaining More Immersive and Emotionally Fulfilling Player Experiences Beyond the Game Itself

Prior research has suggested that digital games can support coping and well-being in certain contexts. Some studies illustrate how games help players cope with trauma and life difficulties [28, 43, 62], while specific game contexts, such as challenging play in *Dark Souls*, have been shown to foster resilience and reflection among players experiencing depression [68, 69]. While recent work on otome games tends to focus on online social support structures that enhance women players’ mental well-being [36], our study offers a complementary lens by examining how players engage in online-to-offline RII practices that extend beyond the game itself.

Built upon these insights and lessons from the nuances and risks associated with women otome players’ RII practices, we propose three high-level design principles by pairing the opportunities surfaced in their RII practices with the corresponding risks and safeguards identified in our findings. These principles are intended as preliminary design directions to support and sustain more immersive and emotionally fulfilling player experiences beyond the game itself, while also mitigating potential risks associated with such extended engagement. Although our work is mainly grounded in this particular sample of women otome players’ experiences and RII practices, we envision that these directions could provide initial steps to help inform not only the future design of otome games but also a broader range of game genres that similarly value players’ continuous and emotionally rich engagement with gameplay both within and outside the game and both online and offline.

6.2.1 Principle 1: Design for Intentional Narrative Openness While Providing Emotional Guard Rails from Potential Dependencies. One key highlight from our findings is that most of our participants’ motivations to engage in RII practices stem from unfulfilled gaps in game design, including storylines that do not happen, emotional care that cannot be personalized, and interactions that cannot be spontaneous. Yet, far from being a design failure, this openness not only leaves imaginative space for creating new stories and narratives but also potentially helps avoid the discrepancy between players’ self-perception and the displayed characteristics of the protagonist. This suggests that game designers of romance-oriented or emotionally driven games may more actively utilize such player-driven creative space. Instead of over-scripting narratives, deliberately leaving space in the level of detail for romantic storylines, everyday character communication, and character development arcs can more actively invite imagination and creation, deepening long-term engagement with game content, narratives, and characters.

Meanwhile, our RQ2 findings also show that this perceived openness can reflect players’ emotional expectations outpacing game design, potentially leading to an overfocus on virtual relationships. In particular, participants’ growing anxiety about not living up to the idealized selves during RII practices and a sense of dissatisfaction with their offline selves and relationships highlight important design directions. As such, designers should consider pairing narrative openness with

player-facing emotional guardrails. For example, one possible feature could be reflective prompts after emotionally intense romantic scenes (e.g., an optional “memory diary” where players can record their feelings about a romantic scene), character messages that affirm players’ offline self-worth beyond idealized romantic performance (e.g., loving messages to remind players of taking care of themselves in their offline lives), or optional pacing reminders before players repeatedly re-enter highly affective storylines (e.g., a gentle prompt encouraging players to pause after repeatedly replaying the same story chapter). The goal is not to foreclose imaginative engagement but to ensure that the space the game opens for player imaginations does not become an over-idealized standard against which they measure and diminish offline lives.

6.2.2 Principle 2: Design for Meaningful Everyday Integration Alongside Enhanced Online-Offline Safety Infrastructure. Another highlight of our findings is that our participants especially value RII experiences that can be seamlessly integrated into their everyday lives, such as text roleplay that involves ordinary companionship and situated emotional support (e.g., during a difficult week) and cosplay commissions for embodied romantic immersion. This suggests that a crucial strategy to make post-game experiences engaging and immersive is to blend naturally with players’ non-game, daily lives. Therefore, it seems important to design the everyday touchpoints that games already provide in offline experiences, such as push notifications, daily character messages, and game-event-driven interactions, to be more personally responsive and spontaneous rather than uniformly scripted. This approach may deepen players’ sense that their experience extends beyond gameplay, rather than abruptly ending when the game closes. This principle may also be applicable to a broader range of games beyond romance games to sustain long-term, post-game engagement.

Yet, our RQ2 findings also show that this blending of game and everyday life raises important design considerations regarding emotional dependency. In particular, participants described re-engagement cycles in which offline post-game engagements can over-prioritize game-related fantasies over real-life experiences. This thus calls for a robust online-offline safety infrastructure built around clear player self-awareness. There are some actionable potential examples, including session-awareness features that detect and remind players after unusual engagement length and frequency; self-reflection prompts that help players to build more progress-aware gameplay experiences; spending transparency tools that prevent reliance by summarizing these purchases over time; and community-norm-setting that promotes healthy fan engagement. In summary, incorporating these features directly into the entire game ecosystem, rather than leaving it entirely community-driven and relying on players to self-regulate, may be particularly important for players with pre-existing emotional vulnerabilities.

6.2.3 Principle 3: Design for Women Players’ Unique Emotional Needs and Women-Centered Safe Spaces. Lastly, our findings reveal that women otome players in this study consistently described offline RII practices as women-only spaces, and this exclusivity was not incidental but deeply valued. To women otome game players, women cosplayers understood gender-specific bodily experiences, emotional rhythms, and relational expectations, which made the experience feel genuinely safe and emotionally authentic. In this sense, such identity-based mutual understanding seems to drive post-game community culture, ensuring predictable interaction boundaries and avoiding potential offense arising from differences in gender, identity, and perspective. Therefore, for games with similarly specific player groups, designers may more actively build community infrastructures to both ensure target experiences and avoid potential identity-specific biases. At the same time, designers and community managers should also consider how to keep such spaces outward-friendly, remaining attentive and prudent to dynamics that could, in some cases, shift from protection toward exclusion (e.g., what some participants described as “anti-male” sentiment).

Meanwhile, such community infrastructure should attend to emotionally vulnerable players within the overall player identity. As our findings show, some participants with pre-existing emotional vulnerabilities can intensify post-game engagement in ways that become damaging to their offline lives. Therefore, game designers, researchers, and community leaders may consider monitoring and addressing emergent post-game activity patterns more promptly to ensure safe play for everyone. In practice, this could involve analyzing community engagement behaviors beyond the game to detect early signs of dependency and responding with both in-game and out-of-game interventions. For example, for the game conversation style, in-game character communication could be shifted toward warmer and more genuinely encouraging language rather than indulgent romantic reinforcement. Another approach to achieve this would be to provide clearer community guidelines for players and offer opt-in self-check prompts or links to community support resources when concerning patterns are detected. As HCI and game research increasingly attend to the diversity of player populations, designing responsively to players' unique emotional needs becomes a significant and ethically urgent direction for future work.

6.3 Limitations and Future Work

First, our recruitment methods could introduce a self-selection bias, as participants who actively attend offline conventions or share their otome game experiences on public platforms may already represent more engaged community members than the broader population of women otome players. In addition, although we intentionally used a combination of various relevant hashtags to reach a broader scope of potential participants who might follow different hashtags online, it is still possible that some community members who did not follow or engage with these hashtags were not reached. Future work could complement interview-based methods with larger-scale surveys or observational approaches to capture a wider range of engagement patterns and include a more diverse sample of players who may or may not practice these specific forms of RII. **Second**, our sample consists entirely of Chinese women otome game players (24 from mainland China and 1 from Hong Kong). Our findings may not directly transfer to women otome players in other cultural contexts, such as Japan, South Korea, or Western countries, where perceptions of this game genre, community norms, and gender dynamics may differ. Future research can examine how RII practices are shaped by different cultural contexts to build a more globally nuanced understanding of post-game, player-character intimate engagement. **Third**, our findings are grounded in the specific context of otome games. While we believe that these empirical insights and design principles from our study are potentially generalizable to other similar gaming contexts, how they may apply to broader game genres and other player groups remains an open question. Future work could investigate whether analogous post-game imaginative practices and associated risks emerge in other emotionally driven game genres, such as narrative RPGs or social simulation games, and whether similar dynamics appear across different player demographics.

7 Conclusion

Otome games, as a romance-centered single-player game genre, have grown rapidly in popularity among women players, particularly in East Asia. Besides their immersive, first-person romantic narratives, otome games often feature post-game player activities to engage with virtual characters, which foster various activities for retrospective imaginative involvement (RII). As shown in our findings, women otome game players in this study have taken various roles (e.g., fandom art creators, commissioners, and roleplayers) to creatively leverage RII practices to extend their affection toward virtual characters across online and offline settings. However, while engaging in personalized and idealized RII practices provides participants with emotional fulfillment that the game itself cannot offer, it may also risk over-idealization and emotional dependency, sometimes, even unrealistic

expectations for offline relationships and repetitive re-engagement cycles on RII for acute emotional needs. These tensions may appear especially salient for participants who described pre-existing emotional difficulties or relationship-related vulnerabilities, and the financial component involved in many paid RII practices may further complicate such tensions and blur the boundary between performance and genuine human connections. Taken together, our findings can inform broader reflections on and future design directions for game-mediated intimacy to go beyond traditional in-game contexts and player–player interactions, to also consider both nuances and risks of character-centered, self-driven, re-imagined, and re-created experiences blurring the boundary between online and offline spaces. In doing so, we hope that these initial insights can help HCI researchers and game designers better support game players’ overall emotional well-being in the future.

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A Appendix

A.1 Supplementary Interview Information

Table 3. Participants' experiences with different forms of RII practices and interview modes.

ID	Otome Game Experience	Cosplay Commissioner	Cosplayer	Text-roleplay Commissioner	Text Roleplayer	Fandom Art Creation	Interview Mode
1	7 months	16/6 months	–	3 months	–	–	Video
2	1 year 6 months	17/1 year 6 months	–	–	–	–	Video
3	1 year 6 months	5/4 months	–	2 months	–	–	Video
4	1 year 2 months	14/1 year	30/1 year	–	–	–	Audio
5	8 months	4/6 months	3/4 months	–	4 months	–	Video
6	6 years 6 months	4/1 year	–	1 year	5 months	4 years	Audio
7	1 year 6 months	8/1 year 2 months	8 months	–	1 year	–	Text
8	2 years	20/1 year 3 months	–	–	–	–	Audio
9	1 year 8 months	10/1 year 5 months	1 year	5 months	1 year	1 year 2 months	Video
10	1 year 6 months	5/4 months	3/4 months	1 month	–	–	Video
11	5 years	6/9 months	–	–	–	–	Video
12	3 years	8/1 year 1 month	–	6 months	–	–	Video
13	3 years 2 months	40/3 years	–	–	–	–	Video
14	6 years	30/1 year 6 months	–	–	–	–	Audio
15	9 years	60/5 years	More than 70/3 years	–	–	7 years	Audio
16	2 years	14/2 years	–	1 year 5 months	–	–	Video
17	9 months	15/4 months	–	–	–	–	Video
18	1 year 10 months	70/1 year	18/6 months	5 months	–	1 year 6 months	Video
19	1 year 2 months	4/10 months	–	11 months	10 months	–	Audio
20	8 years	8/1 year	25/10 months	3 months	–	2 years 6 months	Audio
21	3 months	–	More than 100/3 years	–	3 years 6 months	–	Video
22	10 years	15/2 years	5/1 year	–	1 year	3 years	Video
23	12 years	3/2 years	1/1 year	–	5 months	5 years	Video
24	2 years	25/1 year 11 months	–	1 year 10 months	–	1 year	Audio
25	1 year	2/10 months	10 months	–	–	–	Audio

Note: Otome game experience reflects cumulative active playtime rather than total elapsed time, such that players who paused and resumed play report only their net playing periods; as a result, some participants' RII engagement durations may appear to exceed their reported game experience (e.g., P21), as they may have continued following characters, storylines, and community activities during non-playing periods. Entries in the form of “number / duration” indicate the reported number of participations or commissions and duration of engagement. Duration-only entries indicate that participants reported duration but not counts, except in the Cosplayer column where they indicate general cosplay experience without commissioned work.

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